

Later, I learned that it had taken my friend less than six months to clean up all his "messes." Despite the fact that he owned or controlled many other business enterprises, he plunged enthusiastically into the task of personally reorganizing and revitalizing the three faltering companies.

He quickly pulled the first one out of the corner into which it had been driven by its competitors. He began improving old products, developing new ones and launching an imaginative, aggressive sales campaign that turned the tables on competing firms. He then put the second firm back on its feet by initiating new policies and programs, reducing production costs and increasing output. As for the third company, he arranged refinancing of its obligations, made needed changes in management personnel and soon had the firm on a sound financial footing and operating at a comfortable profit.

"I had quite a workout getting things in order," he told me sometime later. "But I sure enjoyed it—it's always more fun to win a hard fight than an easy one."

"Adversity is the first path to truth," Lord Byron said more than a hundred years ago.

"Calamity is man's true touchstone," Francis Beaumont and John Fletcher wrote in the early 17th Century.

Now, Byron and Beaumont and Fletcher were not businessmen and they did not concern themselves with business in their writings. Yet, the basic truths implicit in their lines are applicable to every present-day businessman and to anyone who hopes to make a success of a business career.

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A machine that is functioning perfectly needs only nominal care. By the same token, a highly prosperous business that operates year after year without problems requires little more than caretaker management. No exceptional ability is needed to run such an enterprise. Unfortunately, the "perfect business" does not exist. Snags, difficulties and crises crop up in